

Haligric Research Integration Series

TIBETAN VAJRAYANA BUDDHISM AND BON

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

*The Roof of the World -- Bon, Vajrayana, the Bardo Thodol, Dzogchen, and the Most Complete Map of
Consciousness and Death in the Sacred Literature*

*"O nobly born, your present awareness, knowing, void, and naked,
is itself the very reality, the All-Good.*

You have always been free."

-- Bardo Thodol

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Introduction -- The Roof of the World and Its Sacred Inheritance

Tibet sits on the highest plateau on earth -- an average elevation of over 4,500 meters, surrounded by the Himalayas to the south and the Kunlun mountains to the north, isolated by geography from the rest of the world in a way that allowed its sacred tradition to develop with unusual depth and continuity. What Tibet produced from the synthesis of its two great sacred streams -- Bon, the ancient indigenous shamanic and animist tradition, and Vajrayana Buddhism, arrived from India beginning in the 7th century CE -- is the most complete and most explicitly documented sacred tradition in the world. A tradition that mapped consciousness, the dying process, the after-death experience, the nature of mind, the structure of reality, and the path to liberation with a precision and depth that remains unmatched in the global sacred literature. The Tibetan Book of the Dead alone is without parallel in any tradition for its specificity about what happens to consciousness after the body dies.

Vajrayana -- The Diamond Vehicle: What Makes the Path Distinct

Tibetan Buddhism is properly called Vajrayana -- the Diamond Vehicle, or the Thunderbolt Path. Where Theravada Buddhism emphasizes the monastic path to liberation understood as unfolding across many lifetimes, and Mahayana Buddhism adds the bodhisattva vow (delaying one's own liberation to help all beings first), Vajrayana claims to offer the fastest possible path to liberation, potentially within a single lifetime, through specific tantric practices: deity visualization, mantra, mudra, energy body work, and the direct recognition of the nature of mind. What distinguishes Tibetan Buddhism even among tantric paths is the completeness of its integration -- meditation, deity visualization, mantra, energy body work, death preparation, and philosophical non-dualism are all understood as dimensions of a single unified path.

Bon -- The Ancient Shamanic Religion of Tibet

Bon is the ancient indigenous shamanic and animist tradition of the Tibetan plateau, with roots in the Zhang Zhung civilization that preceded the Tibetan Empire. The traditional Buddhist account presents Bon as a degenerated tradition that incorporated Buddhist elements after Buddhism's arrival. The Bon tradition's own account presents it as the original teaching of Tonpa Shenrab Miwoche -- a pre-Buddhist teacher of enlightenment who predates Siddhartha Gautama by thousands of years. Contemporary scholarship suggests that Bon and Buddhism developed in parallel, each influencing the other deeply, producing the specific synthesis that characterizes the Tibetan sacred world. Bon is not merely Buddhism's predecessor. It is a complete and living sacred tradition in its own right with its own Dzogchen -- the recognition that the nature of mind is already perfect, arrived at through a completely indigenous Tibetan route.

Bon Cosmology -- Three Worlds, the Soul, and the Shaman

Bon cosmology divides reality into three realms: the upper realm (Yeru) of sky and divine beings, the middle realm (Bardu) of the human world and its spirits, and the lower realm (Yodu) of underground waters and earth spirits. This three-world structure is the universal shamanic cosmological map -- identical in its basic architecture to the Siberian shamanic tradition, the Norse world tree (Yggdrasil's three roots), the Slavic tradition's three realms, and the indigenous American traditions that recognize upper, middle, and lower worlds. The Bon universe is populated by spirit beings: the lha (divine beings of the upper realm), the tsen (warrior spirits of the middle realm, associated with rocks and passes), and the lu

(serpentine beings of the lower realm, associated with water and earth -- closely related to the Indian naga).

Bon recognizes multiple soul components in the human being -- a complex soul anatomy that parallels the Egyptian Ka/Ba/Akh system, the Yoruba concept of Ori and multiple soul parts, and the Chinese understanding of po and hun souls. The la is the life soul -- the vital force that animates the body and that can be captured, frightened away, or lost during illness or trauma. The Bon shaman's primary healing function is the retrieval of the la -- journeying to wherever it has been taken or fled and restoring it to the body. This soul retrieval tradition is the direct precedent for what contemporary shamanic healing traditions call soul retrieval work.

Bon Ceremonies -- Step-by-Step

The Bon specialist (shen or bonpo) conducts specific ceremonies for the community's wellbeing: propitiation of local deities, soul retrieval, divination, and the great death rituals that guide the consciousness of the deceased through the after-death experience.

Step 1 -- Identification: The shen identifies through divination which specific local deity has been offended or requires attention.

Step 2 -- Preparation: Specific offerings (food, incense, specific colors of cloth) are prepared according to the identified deity's preferences.

Step 3 -- Invocation: The shen calls the deity through specific mantras in the Bon tradition (using the Bon sacred language, which has elements of the ancient Zhang Zhung language).

Step 4 -- The Offering: The offerings are presented with specific prayers acknowledging the deity's power and requesting the community's wellbeing.

Step 5 -- Healing: If the ceremony is for healing, the shen works with the specific energetic condition identified in divination.

Step 6 -- Closing: The deity is formally thanked and released. For soul retrieval (Bdag 'gug), when illness is diagnosed as soul loss, the shen performs specific ceremonies to locate and restore the wandering soul component through visualization, specific mantras, sacred objects, and the shen's capacity to work in the spirit world directly.

Zhang Zhung and the Original Bon Tradition

The Zhang Zhung civilization -- centered in western Tibet around Mount Kailash (the most sacred mountain in the Bon, Hindu, Jain, and Buddhist traditions simultaneously) -- is the source of the most ancient layer of the Bon tradition. Zhang Zhung was a sophisticated civilization with its own language (now extinct), its own sacred texts, and its own high culture. It was conquered by the Tibetan Empire in approximately the 7th century CE. Mount Kailash (Tise in Zhang Zhung, Gang Rinpoche in Tibetan -- Precious Snow Mountain) is the axis mundi of the Bon tradition -- the world pillar around which the cosmos revolves, the home of the sky god Sipaimen, and the sacred center from which the four great rivers of Asia (the Indus, the Brahmaputra, the Karnali/Ganges tributary, and the Sutlej) flow outward in the four directions. The Bon tradition's circumambulation of Mount Kailash goes counter-clockwise (the reverse of the Buddhist circumambulation direction) -- and both traditions have been circling the mountain simultaneously for over a thousand years.

How Buddhism Came to Tibet -- The Three Transmissions

The First Transmission: King Songtsen Gampo (617-649/650 CE) united Tibet into the first Tibetan Empire and invited Buddhist scholars, had the Tibetan script created to enable translation of Buddhist texts, and established the first Buddhist temples. The Second

Transmission: King Trisong Detsen (742-797 CE) invited the Indian pandita Santaraksita and the tantric master Padmasambhava to Tibet. Santaraksita established the philosophical and monastic foundation; Padmasambhava subdued the local spirits and demons who were obstructing Buddhism's establishment, incorporating many of them into the Buddhist pantheon as protectors rather than destroying them. The first Tibetan monastery -- Samye -- was built in approximately 779 CE. The Third Transmission: After King Langdarma's persecution (838-842 CE) nearly extinguished Tibetan Buddhism, the Second Diffusion was centered on the Indian master Atisha's arrival in Tibet in 1042 CE and produced the systematic structure of Tibetan Buddhism that persists today.

The Meeting -- Buddhism and Bon in Synthesis

The synthesis of Buddhism and Bon was not a one-time event but a centuries-long mutual absorption. Many elements that outside observers identify as distinctively Tibetan Buddhist are, in fact, Bon in origin, incorporated so completely into the Buddhist tradition that the two are now difficult to separate in practice: the prayer flag, the prayer wheel, specific forms taken by certain protector deities, and the specific ceremonies used for managing the spirits of the dead. Conversely, contemporary Bon has absorbed Buddhist philosophical vocabulary, monastic organization, and even sections of the Buddhist canon. The clearest single hinge-point in this synthesis is Padmasambhava's work at Samye in the 8th century: rather than destroying the indigenous spirits obstructing the monastery's construction, he bound them by oath to become protectors of the Dharma. This is the founding template for the entire synthesis that followed -- nothing is destroyed, everything is transformed.

Padmasambhava -- The Lotus-Born Master

Padmasambhava (Guru Rinpoche -- Precious Teacher) is one of the most significant figures in Tibetan religious history -- the Indian tantric master credited with the introduction of Vajrayana Buddhism to Tibet and the subjugation of Tibet's indigenous spirits. He is described as having been born miraculously from a lotus in a lake, as a teacher of extraordinary mastery over both sutra and tantra, as a practitioner of the highest Dzogchen realization, and as a being who transcended ordinary human limitations in ways that the tradition treats as literal rather than metaphorical.

His foundational innovation in Tibet was the transformation of local spirits from obstacles into allies -- the specific synthesis between Bon and Buddhism that defines Tibetan sacred culture. He hid termas (treasure texts) in rocks, water, and the minds of specific disciples, to be revealed by designated treasure-finders (terton) in future centuries when humanity would be ready to receive them. The terma tradition has produced an extraordinary body of sacred literature across the centuries -- including the Bardo Thodol, which was hidden by Padmasambhava and discovered by Karma Lingpa in the 14th century.

HALIGRIC LENS: Padmasambhava's transformation of Tibet's indigenous spirits from obstacles into protectors is the most complete example of sacred synthesis in Tibetan history -- and a model for the Haligric approach to every tradition. Nothing is destroyed. Everything is transformed. The energy that previously blocked the sacred work becomes, when correctly recognized and rightly related to, the guardian of it.

The Four Schools of Tibetan Buddhism

Tibetan Buddhism crystallized into four major schools over the 11th-15th centuries -- each with its own emphasis, its own transmission lineage, its own sacred texts, and its own distinctive practices, while sharing the common foundation of Vajrayana Buddhism and the Bodhisattva ideal. The four schools are: Nyingma (Ancient Ones -- the oldest school, tracing directly to Padmasambhava), Kagyu (Oral Transmission -- emphasizing Mahamudra and the Six Yogas of Naropa), Sakya (Grey Earth -- established by the Khon family in 1073 CE,

known for the Lamdre Path-Result teaching), and Gelug (Virtuous Way -- the newest and now largest school, founded by Tsongkhapa in the 14th century, and the school of the Dalai Lamas).

The Nyingma School -- The Ancient Ones

Nyingma is the oldest school of Tibetan Buddhism, tracing its origin directly to Padmasambhava's 8th-century transmission. The Nyingma school is distinguished by its nine-vehicle (theg pa rim pa dgu) structure of the Buddhist path -- organizing all Buddhist teachings from the most basic to the most advanced into a comprehensive graduated system with Dzogchen at the apex. The Nyingma school has no single institutional head -- it is organized around a network of great masters and their lineages rather than a centralized authority. Its great masters -- Longchenpa (1308-1364), Jigme Lingpa (1730-1798), Dudjom Rinpoche (1904-1987) -- are among the most celebrated teachers in all of Tibetan Buddhism. The Nyingma school's primary practice transmission is the Longchen Nyingthig (Heart Essence of the Vast Expanse) -- a terma cycle discovered by Jigme Lingpa that contains the most complete and most widely practiced Dzogchen teaching lineage in the contemporary world.

A note on institutional accountability: Sogyal Rinpoche, author of the influential Tibetan Book of Living and Dying and founder of the international Rigpa organization, brought Nyingma teaching to a wide Western audience beginning in the late 1970s. His legacy is inseparable from serious abuse allegations that became public in 2017. An independent investigation commissioned by Rigpa itself found that Sogyal Rinpoche had subjected students to "physical, sexual, and emotional abuse" over many years. He died in 2019. The teachings he transmitted were genuine; the institution he built around them was harmed by his conduct. The distinction between a tradition's teachings and any individual teacher's behavior is essential to maintain.

Terma -- The Hidden Treasure Texts

Terma (Tib: gter ma -- treasure) are sacred texts, objects, and transmissions hidden by Padmasambhava and other masters in rocks, water, space, and the minds of specific disciples, to be discovered by designated treasure-finders (terton) in future centuries when the time is right. The terma tradition has produced a vast body of sacred literature across twelve centuries -- including the Bardo Thodol (discovered by Karma Lingpa in the 14th century), the Longchen Nyingthig (discovered by Jigme Lingpa in the 18th century), and the Rinchen Terdzo -- the great treasury of precious termas compiled by Jamgon Kongtrul in the 19th century.

HALIGRIC LENS: The terma tradition is the most literal expression in any tradition of the understanding that sacred knowledge can be transmitted across time -- that a teaching planted in the consciousness of a student by an enlightened master can flower centuries later when the conditions are right. The Haligric Living Altar concept -- sending love to past selves and past versions of one's children through the non-linear nature of time -- operates on the same understanding: that intentional sacred energy transcends linear time and reaches its destination when the recipient is ready.

The Kagyu School -- The Oral Transmission

Kagyu (Oral Transmission) traces its lineage through the Indian mahasiddha Tilopa (928-1009 CE) to Naropa (1016-1100 CE) to the Tibetan translator Marpa (1012-1097 CE) to Milarepa (1040-1123 CE) to Gampopa (1079-1153 CE), who established the Kagyu as a distinct school. The Kagyu school's primary transmission is Mahamudra (Great Seal) -- the direct recognition of the nature of mind as it is, without elaboration or modification. The Kagyu also preserves the Six Yogas of Naropa -- advanced tantric practices including tummo

(inner heat), the illusory body, dream yoga, luminosity yoga, bardo yoga, and consciousness transference (phowa). The Karmapa lineage, the head of the Karma Kagyu sub-school, has been contested since 1992 between two claimants -- Ogyen Trinley Dorje and Trinley Thaye Dorje. The two claimants met in France in 2018, issued a joint statement, and in December 2023 jointly announced they would co-oversee the recognition of the next Shamar Rinpoche together -- a significant act of reconciliation.

Milarepa -- Tibet's Greatest Yogi

Milarepa (1040-1123 CE) is the most beloved figure in Tibetan sacred history -- a man who began as a practitioner of black magic who used sorcery to kill relatives who had stolen his family's inheritance, was brought to crushing shame and repentance by his own mother, and was sent to the master Marpa, who subjected him to years of apparently arbitrary labor and humiliation before transmitting the Kagyu teachings. He then spent the rest of his life in mountain caves, practicing in extreme conditions, and achieving complete enlightenment -- expressing his realization in songs (Milarepa's Hundred Thousand Songs remain one of the most celebrated bodies of sacred poetry in the world) that combined philosophical precision with earthy directness and humor.

The Sakya School -- Path and Result

Sakya (Grey Earth) was founded in 1073 CE by Khon Konchok Gyalpo, establishing the tradition of the Khon family as the hereditary heads of the Sakya school. The Sakya school's primary teaching is Lamdre (Path-Result) -- a comprehensive practice system integrating sutra and tantra. The Sakya school had its greatest political moment in the 13th century when the Sakya Pandita (1182-1251 CE) established the patron-priest relationship with Mongol rulers that gave the Sakya school temporal authority over Tibet -- establishing the model of theocratic governance that would eventually be institutionalized through the Dalai Lama system. The office's succession rules changed substantially in 2014, shifting from lifetime tenure toward three-year terms rotating between the two branches of the Khon family. The current 43rd Sakya Trizin, Gyana Vajra Rinpoche, was enthroned in March 2022 under this new system.

The Gelug School -- The Way of Virtue

Gelug (Virtuous Way) is the newest and now largest school of Tibetan Buddhism -- founded by Je Tsongkhapa Lobzang Drakpa (1357-1419 CE) as a reform movement emphasizing strict monastic discipline, rigorous philosophical study, and a systematic graduated approach to the spiritual path. Tsongkhapa's Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path (Lam Rim Chenmo) is the most comprehensive systematic presentation of the complete Buddhist path in Tibetan literature. A widely held misconception holds that the Dalai Lama is the Gelug school's formal head; the actual office is the Ganden Tripa, a position reached through decades of monastic study and debate rather than reincarnation, held for a seven-year term. The 105th Ganden Tripa, Lobsang Dorjee, was enthroned in November 2024.

The Tulku System -- Recognized Reincarnations

The tulku system -- the formal recognition of specific children as the reincarnations of deceased masters -- is the most distinctive institutional feature of Tibetan Buddhism. When a senior lama dies, a search is conducted for a child born at approximately the right time who demonstrates recognition of the previous incarnation's possessions, associates, and names. The process involves consultation of oracles, examination of propitious signs, and specific tests designed to distinguish the reincarnation from other children. The tulku is typically brought to a monastery for training from a young age -- entering a process of education understood as the recovery of the previous life's understanding rather than the acquisition

of new knowledge. The tulku system currently recognizes several thousand living tulkus worldwide. The system has come under strain through the Chinese government's insistence on the right to approve tulku recognitions within China -- a direct political intrusion into the most sacred institutional mechanism of Tibetan Buddhism.

The Dalai Lamas -- Avalokiteshvara Incarnate

The Dalai Lama (Ocean Teacher) institution began with the retroactive recognition of Gendun Drup (1391-1474 CE) as the First Dalai Lama. The institution became politically significant with the Fifth Dalai Lama (1617-1682 CE) -- known as the Great Fifth -- who with Mongol military support unified Tibet under Gelug leadership and built the Potala Palace in Lhasa. The current and 14th Dalai Lama -- Tenzin Gyatso, born 1935 -- was recognized at age two, enthroned at age four, and assumed political leadership of Tibet at age fifteen in 1950 -- the same year Chinese forces invaded Tibet. After the 1959 Tibetan uprising was suppressed, the Dalai Lama fled to Dharamsala in northern India, where the Tibetan Government in Exile has been based since. He received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1989.

On July 2, 2025 -- shortly before his 90th birthday -- the 14th Dalai Lama issued a formal statement affirming that the institution of the Dalai Lama will continue, and that only the Gaden Phodrang Trust has sole authority to recognize the future reincarnation: "No one else has any such authority to interfere in this matter." In July 2025, five UN human rights experts sent a formal communication to Beijing expressing "grave concern" over Chinese laws and policies asserting state control over Tibetan Buddhist reincarnation. The US Congress passed a law sanctioning Chinese officials who interfere in the Dalai Lama succession process. China maintains that Tibetan Buddhist reincarnations require government approval under Chinese law -- a claim the international community, including the UN and EU, has repeatedly rejected. Gedhun Cheokyi Nyima -- the Panchen Lama recognized by the 14th Dalai Lama in 1995, when he was six years old -- has been held by the Chinese government for 30 years. In June 2026 the Dalai Lama departed Dharamshala for medical treatment in Delhi.

Sowa Rigpa -- Tibetan Medicine and the Living Wellness Tradition

Sowa Rigpa (The Art of Healing) is the Tibetan medical tradition -- one of the most complete and most continuously practiced holistic medical systems in the world, combining indigenous Tibetan healing knowledge (rooted in Bon), influences absorbed from Indian Ayurveda, and Chinese medicine, organized within the specific cosmological framework of Tibetan Buddhism. At Sowa Rigpa's foundation is the understanding that the human body is composed of five elements, manifesting physiologically as three humors (nyepa): lung (wind), tripa (bile), and beken (phlegm), each governing distinct physiological and psychological functions. Health is the state in which these three humors flow in balanced equilibrium; illness arises when seasonal change, diet, lifestyle, or emotional disturbance causes a humor to become imbalanced.

Diagnosis in Sowa Rigpa is entirely non-invasive, built on four methods: visual observation, patient interrogation, pulse examination at multiple points on the wrist to assess the condition of internal organs, and detailed analysis of a patient's morning urine for color, vapor, sediment, and bubbling. Treatment follows a graduated approach, beginning with dietary and behavioral adjustment before proceeding to herbal formulas, and where needed, external therapies including Ku Nye massage and moxibustion. Meditation and mantra recitation are integrated directly into treatment. The Men-Tsee-Khang (Tibetan Medical and Astrological Institute), founded in exile in Dharamsala, serves as Sowa Rigpa's institutional center today -- training practitioners and maintaining clinical practice that has spread throughout the Himalayan region, Mongolia, Buryatia, Russia, and increasingly into Europe and North America.

The Three Roots -- Guru, Yidam, Dakini

The Three Roots are the foundational sacred relationships of the Vajrayana path -- the three sources from which the practitioner receives the blessings necessary for practice and realization. The Guru (Lama) is the root of blessings -- the teacher who transmits the lineage through direct personal relationship, who embodies the tradition's realization in a human form the student can relate to, and who recognizes and guides the student's own developing understanding. In Vajrayana, the relationship with the guru is held as more essential than any other sacred relationship. The Yidam (Tutelary Deity) is the root of attainments -- the specific deity form through which the practitioner works in sadhana practice (described below). The Dakini (Sky Dancer) is the root of activity -- the feminine principle of awakened energy in its most wild, most energized, most non-institutionally-controlled form: simultaneously the consort of male deities, independent enlightened female figures (Vajrayogini, Tara), and the principle of inspiration and transmission.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Dakini is the Tibetan Buddhist expression of the divine feminine in its most wild, most energized form. Unlike the suppressed Heavenly Mother of some Western theologies, the Dakini in Vajrayana is one of the three fundamental sources of the entire path. She dances in the sky. She cuts through delusion with her curved blade. She holds the skull cup of transformed consciousness. The Haligric tradition honors her completely.

Ngondro -- The Foundational Practices, Step-by-Step

Ngondro ("that which goes before") is the common foundational practice shared by all four schools of Tibetan Buddhism and by Bon -- the actual, lived entry point into Vajrayana practice for the overwhelming majority of practitioners. Vajrayana teachers are emphatic that "foundational" does not mean "lesser": ngondro is held to be a complete and sufficient practice in its own right, capable of carrying a practitioner all the way to full enlightenment.

Step 1 -- The Four Contemplations: Before beginning the counted practices, a practitioner reflects deeply on four foundational truths: the rarity and value of a human rebirth with the freedom to practice; the certainty of death and the impermanence of everything; the precise workings of karma, cause, and effect; and the pervasive unsatisfactoriness of ordinary existence.

Step 2 -- Refuge and Prostrations: The practitioner recites the refuge prayer while performing full-body prostrations, traditionally 100,000 of them. The physical act of repeatedly lowering the body to the ground works directly against the habitual posture of self-importance.

Step 3 -- Vajrasattva Purification: 100,000 repetitions of the Vajrasattva mantra combined with specific visualization for the purification of negative karma and broken vows.

Step 4 -- Mandala Offering: 100,000 repetitions of the offering of the entire universe to the objects of refuge -- the practice that specifically purifies attachment.

Step 5 -- Guru Yoga: 100,000 repetitions of a practice of merging one's own mind with the mind of the root guru -- the practice that opens the student to the transmission that makes all subsequent Vajrayana practice possible.

A complete ngondro -- four practices at 100,000 repetitions each -- represents roughly 1,500 hours of sustained practice, commonly undertaken over months in dedicated retreat or stretched across years of daily practice. This is Tibetan Buddhism's actual answer to what this library elsewhere calls a wellness or self-care framework: not a single ceremony but a long, physically demanding, repeated discipline.

Abhisheka -- The Empowerment Ceremony, Step-by-Step

Abhisheka (Sanskrit: sprinkling or anointing; wang in Tibetan) is the ritual empowerment ceremony that authorizes a student to undertake a specific tantric practice. Without receiving it directly from a qualified vajra master, a practitioner has no authority to undertake the practice at all. The ceremony is understood not as a symbolic formality but as an actual transmission -- the direct planting, in the disciple's mind, of the seed of the specific enlightened state the practice is meant to cultivate.

Step 1 -- Preliminary Preparation: The lama meditates and recites the mantra of the specific deity, ritually blesses and purifies the ceremonial space, and performs rites to clear away obstructing forces.

Step 2 -- Entering the Mandala: The lama and assembled students visualize themselves as the mandala of the deity being introduced, and invite the actual enlightened being to descend and merge with the visualized form.

Step 3 -- The Four Empowerments: A complete empowerment in the highest tantric class moves through four stages: the Vase Empowerment (purifying the body), the Secret Empowerment (purifying speech), the Wisdom Empowerment (purifying the mind), and the Word Empowerment (purifying the subtle body and authorizing Dzogchen).

Step 4 -- Receiving the Samaya: The student receives the samaya -- the sacred bond between teacher and student -- and the specific commitments associated with the empowerment's practice.

The Three Kayas -- Dharmakaya, Sambhogakaya, Nirmanakaya

The doctrine of the Three Kayas (trikaya -- three bodies) describes the different dimensions in which enlightenment expresses itself. The Dharmakaya (Truth Body) is enlightenment in its most fundamental form -- formless, boundless awareness itself, identical with ultimate reality and with the nature of mind that Dzogchen calls rigpa. It has no shape, no color, no location. The Sambhogakaya (Enjoyment Body) is the subtle, luminous form enlightenment takes when it expresses itself for the benefit of advanced bodhisattvas in pure realms -- radiant, ornamented deity forms such as those generated in sadhana practice and mapped by the Five Buddha Families. The Nirmanakaya (Emanation Body) is enlightenment made concrete in ordinary physical form -- a body born, aging, teaching, and dying within history. The historical Buddha Shakyamuni is the paradigm case; so is every tulku recognized as the physical continuation of a previous master's realization. The three are not three separate beings but three simultaneous dimensions of a single enlightened reality.

Deity Visualization (Sadhana) -- The Core Vajrayana Practice, Step-by-Step

Deity visualization (sadhana practice) is the distinctive core of Vajrayana practice -- the specific technique through which the practitioner generates themselves as a specific deity, experiencing the non-dual recognition of their own nature as primordially pure through the vehicle of the deity's form. In Vajrayana practice, the practitioner does not pray to a deity as an external being -- the practitioner becomes the deity through a specific visualization process. The deity's qualities (compassion, wisdom, clarity, power) are not foreign to the practitioner but are the practitioner's own primordially pure nature seen clearly.

Step 1 -- Refuge and Bodhicitta: Taking refuge in the Three Jewels and generating Bodhicitta -- the aspiration to achieve liberation for the benefit of all beings.

Step 2 -- Emptiness Meditation: Resting briefly in the recognition of emptiness -- understanding that all phenomena, including the self, are empty of inherent independent existence.

Step 3 -- The Seed Syllable: From the state of emptiness, the seed syllable (bija) of the deity appears -- the compressed sonic form of the deity's essence.

Step 4 -- The Deity Form: The seed syllable transforms into the complete visualization of the deity -- with specific colors, implements, expressions, and ornaments that encode specific qualities of awakened mind.

Step 5 -- Self-Identification: The practitioner recognizes themselves as the deity -- not the ordinary self pretending to be divine, but the ordinary self's obscurations dissolved to reveal the primordially pure nature that the deity's form expresses.

Step 6 -- The Mantra: The deity's specific mantra is recited -- the sound that is the deity's activity in the world, the vibrational form of the deity's specific quality.

Step 7 -- The Dissolution: The visualization dissolves -- deity form dissolves into light, light into seed syllable, seed syllable into space. The practitioner rests in the open awareness that remains.

Step 8 -- The Dedication: The merit of the practice is dedicated to all beings' liberation. The practice is complete.

The Five Buddha Families -- Complete Reference

The Five Buddha Families are the Vajrayana system's most complete map of awakened mind -- organizing the five basic qualities of enlightened awareness into five distinct expressions, each associated with a specific direction, color, element, wisdom, and transformed poison. The Five Buddha Families are the Vajrayana map of what happens when the five poisons are recognized in their nature: Anger, directly seen, reveals the Mirror-Like Wisdom that perceives reality without distortion. Pride, directly seen, reveals the Equalizing Wisdom that recognizes all beings as equally buddha in nature. Desire, directly seen, reveals the Discriminating Wisdom that perceives the unique particularity of every phenomenon with perfect clarity. Jealousy, directly seen, reveals the All-Accomplishing Wisdom that acts spontaneously and perfectly for the benefit of all. Ignorance, directly seen, reveals the Dharmadhatu Wisdom -- the awareness of the nature of reality itself.

HALIGRIC LENS: The Five Buddha Families are the most complete expression in any tradition of the Haligrig understanding that nothing in the human being's nature is an obstacle to be eliminated -- everything is potential wisdom waiting to be recognized. The tradition does not ask you to stop feeling anger, desire, or jealousy. It asks you to look at what those energies actually are beneath the story that surrounds them. What you find is not a problem. It is a wisdom.

Mantra -- Om Mani Padme Hum, the Complete Teaching

The mantra Om Mani Padme Hum (in Tibetan, Om Mani Peme Hung) is the most widely chanted mantra in the Tibetan Buddhist tradition -- the mantra of Avalokiteshvara (Chenrezig in Tibetan), the bodhisattva of compassion. The six syllables correspond to the purification of the six realms of existence and the six perfections: Om purifies the realm of the gods and embodies generosity. Ma purifies the realm of jealous gods and embodies ethics. Ni purifies the human realm and embodies patience. Pad purifies the animal realm and embodies diligence. Me purifies the hungry ghost realm and embodies concentration. Hum purifies the hell realm and embodies wisdom. The 14th Dalai Lama has said: "It is very good to recite the mantra Om Mani Padme Hum, but while you are doing it, you should be thinking on its meaning, for the meaning of the six syllables is great and vast."

Mandala and the Mandala Offering -- Step-by-Step

A mandala (Sanskrit: circle) is a symmetrical, concentrically-organized diagram representing the complete residence of an enlightened being -- the deity's pure-land palace, mapped in precise geometric form. The Mandala Offering is one of the four Ngondro practices: the

offering of the entire visualized universe to the Buddhas and teachers as a practice that specifically purifies attachment.

Step 1 -- The Base: The practitioner holds or visualizes a mandala offering plate as the base representing the golden ground of the universe.

Step 2 -- The Outer Ring: A ring of grain is placed around the base's rim, representing the iron mountain range that encircles the cosmos.

Step 3 -- Mount Meru and the Four Continents: Handfuls of grain are placed at the center (Mount Meru) and at the four cardinal points (the four continents of traditional cosmology), each placement accompanied by specific mantras.

Step 4 -- The Offering Substances: Additional grain, jewels, or symbolic objects are added to represent the sun, moon, and the seven precious possessions of a universal monarch.

Step 5 -- The Offering Itself: The practitioner lifts the completed mandala and mentally offers the entire visualized universe to the Buddhas, the teachers, and all sentient beings' enlightenment.

Step 6 -- The Release: The grain is swept off the plate, and the mandala is rebuilt from empty base to full offering, traditionally repeated many times in a single practice session.

The Bardo Thodol -- The Tibetan Book of the Dead

The Bardo Thodol (Liberation Through Hearing in the Intermediate State) was discovered as a terma by Karma Lingpa in the 14th century and attributed to Padmasambhava. It is read aloud to the dying and the recently deceased to guide consciousness through the states that follow death. The Bardo Thodol identifies six bardos (intermediate states): the Bardo of Waking Life (ordinary waking consciousness), the Bardo of Dream (the dream state as preparation for death), the Bardo of Meditation (specific practice states during life), the Bardo of Dying (the dying process), the Bardo of Dharmata (the luminous nature-of-mind encounters after death), and the Bardo of Becoming (the transitional state moving toward rebirth).

The Bardo of Dying: At the moment of death, a luminous clear light -- the ground luminosity or mother clear light -- arises in the dying person's awareness. This is the fundamental nature of mind itself becoming directly visible as ordinary consciousness dissolves. A practitioner who has prepared through Dzogchen or Mahamudra practice will recognize this clear light as the nature of their own mind and merge with it -- achieving liberation at the moment of death. Those who do not recognize it continue into the Bardo of Dharmata, where the consciousness encounters the peaceful and wrathful deities -- the Five Buddha Families in their peaceful forms, followed by the same energies in their wrathful forms. The instruction is always the same: recognize the brilliant wisdom light as your own nature and merge with it. In the Bardo of Becoming, the consciousness moves toward rebirth in a hallucinatory experience of wind, darkness, and confusion.

The Bardo of Dying -- Step-by-Step

Step 1 -- The Dissolution of the Elements: The five physical elements dissolve in sequence -- earth into water (heaviness, sinking sensation), water into fire (dryness), fire into wind (loss of body heat), wind into consciousness (shallow breathing stops).

Step 2 -- The White Appearance: The white element inherited from the father descends from the crown toward the heart. The practitioner experiences a vast white sky, like moonlight.

Step 3 -- The Red Increase: The red element inherited from the mother rises from the navel toward the heart. The practitioner experiences a vast red sky, like sunset.

Step 4 -- The Black Near-Attainment: When the two elements meet at the heart, consciousness becomes like a vast black sky, and ordinary consciousness dissolves into unconsciousness.

Step 5 -- The Clear Light (Dharmata): After the dark experience, the nature of mind is unveiled -- the clear light of dharmata, the primordially pure awareness that is the ground of all experience. A practitioner who has trained in meditation may recognize this as their own nature and be liberated on the spot.

Step 6 -- The Reading Aloud: The Bardo Thodol instructs that these teachings should be read aloud to the dying person during the dying process and to the deceased body during the first few days after death -- consciousness continues to be present and capable of hearing and potentially recognizing the instructions, even after the body's vital signs have ceased.

"O nobly born, now the clear light of reality itself dawns upon you. Recognize it. O nobly born, your present awareness, vacant, naked, is itself the very reality, the All-Good. You have always been free." -- Bardo Thodol, instruction at the moment of death

Tukdam and the Three Days After Death

Tibetan Buddhist tradition holds that clinical death does not mark the moment consciousness actually departs the body -- the subtlest level of mind is believed capable of remaining for up to three days or longer, depending on the circumstances of death and the individual's own level of realization. This is why the Bardo Thodol's teaching on the clear light corresponds to a practical instruction observed by Tibetan communities: after a peaceful death, the body is left completely undisturbed for three days or more, understood as a critical window in which the dying person's consciousness completes its transition rather than being prematurely dislodged by handling the body.

Tukdam (thugs dam) is the specific meditative state in which advanced practitioners are believed to remain after clinical death -- heart stopped, breath absent, brain activity ceased by every conventional medical measure -- while the body itself shows minimal signs of decomposition and retains a lifelike appearance for days, and in documented cases as long as two to three weeks. Tibetan tradition holds that the practitioner's consciousness has merged with the Clear Light, and that the body will show a specific physical sign at the exact moment consciousness finally departs and ordinary decomposition begins. Tukdam remains an active subject of Western scientific study, actively supported by the 14th Dalai Lama. A 2024 forensic case report in *Forensic Science International: Reports* documented two cases of delayed decompositional changes in Tibetan monastic communities in India, with systematic photography and external measures. Researchers have not yet reached a settled scientific explanation for the observed preservation.

Dzogchen -- The Great Perfection

Dzogchen (Great Perfection) is the highest teaching of both the Nyingma school of Tibetan Buddhism and the Bon tradition -- the direct recognition of the nature of mind (rigpa in Tibetan: awareness or recognition) as it already is, without modification, elaboration, or path-building. Dzogchen teaches that rigpa -- primordial awareness -- is already and always present, that the path is recognition rather than achievement, that the practitioner is not progressing toward something they do not yet have but recognizing what was never absent. The difference between a Buddha and an ordinary being, in Dzogchen, is not that the Buddha has more rigpa -- it is that the Buddha recognizes rigpa and the ordinary person does not.

Dzogchen practice involves two primary approaches: trekcho (cutting through) -- resting in the recognition of rigpa without modification, elaboration, or correction; and togal (direct crossing) -- the further development of that recognition into the direct perception of the

spontaneous display of rigpa as light. Advanced total practitioners report specific visual phenomena -- lights, spheres, chains of crystal spheres called thigle -- that the tradition understands as the direct perception of consciousness's own natural energy. The tradition of rainbow body (jalu) -- in which highly realized Dzogchen practitioners at death leave no physical remains except hair and nails, their bodies dissolving into light -- has been documented in hundreds of cases across Tibetan history and continues to be reported. A 2024 peer-reviewed analysis in *Mission Confessions* (Vol. 13, Issue 2) provided the most recent scholarly review of rainbow body documentation, classifying the phenomenon and examining both traditional accounts and contemporary scientific perspectives.

HALIGRIC LENS: Dzogchen is the Tibetan Buddhist tradition's most precise and most direct statement of the Haligric recognition: the divine does not live above the human being waiting to be earned or appeased. It IS the human being's own awareness -- already present, already perfect, already complete. The only practice is recognition. The only obstacle is the habit of non-recognition. Different name. Exact same recognition.

Mahamudra -- The Great Seal

Mahamudra (Great Seal) is the highest teaching of the Kagyu school and the parallel to Dzogchen in the Sarma (New Translation) schools. Like Dzogchen, Mahamudra points directly to the nature of mind -- but through a slightly different approach described as "going with the grain" of experience rather than "cutting through" it. The Mahamudra pointing-out instruction typically involves three steps: the teacher demonstrates the nature of mind through a specific question or action that stops the ordinary conceptual process, the student has a direct glimpse of the nature of mind, and the teacher confirms the recognition. The subsequent practice of Mahamudra is the stabilization of that recognition -- resting in the nature of mind while thoughts, emotions, and experiences arise and dissolve within it, like waves in an ocean that never leave the ocean.

The 84 Mahasiddhas -- Awakening in Ordinary Life

The 84 Mahasiddhas (Great Accomplished Ones) are the semi-legendary Indian tantric masters from whom the entire Vajrayana transmission traces its descent -- extraordinary practitioners who achieved complete enlightenment while living as fishermen, brewers, cobblers, kings, prostitutes, hunters, and blacksmiths, outside the monastic context and without renouncing ordinary life. Traditional sources follow the 12th-century Indian scholar Abhayadatta Sri's collected biographies. Scholarly comparison of Abhayadatta Sri's list against a separate Vajrasana list finds only around 34 names held in common between them, and the number varies between 84 and 88 depending on tradition -- meaning "84 Mahasiddhas" functions as a symbolically complete category naming the full range of ordinary lives realization can appear within. A fisherman, a washerwoman, a gambler, and a slave are among the tradition's own accounts of where its most exalted transmission began -- a reminder built into the tradition itself that realization was never actually confined to formal authority.

Prayer Flags and Prostrations -- Two Everyday Practices, Step-by-Step

Prayer Flags (lung ta -- wind horse) are rectangular cloths, usually in five colors (blue, white, red, green, yellow -- representing sky, air, fire, water, and earth), printed with mantras and prayers, hung outdoors so the wind carries the printed prayers outward into the world. Ceremony: Flags are traditionally hung on auspicious days determined by the Tibetan calendar, strung in the traditional five-color sequence always from a higher point to a lower point, and blessed with specific prayers at the moment of hanging. As each wind moves the

flags, the prayers are released into the world -- the blowing is not a metaphor but the actual activity of the practice.

Prostrations (chagchel) -- Full-body prostrations form one of the five ngondro practices (performed 100,000 times) but are also practiced as a regular daily practice and performed at temples and sacred sites. Step 1 -- The Joined Hands: Both hands are pressed together at the heart, then raised to touch the crown (body), throat (speech), and heart (mind) -- acknowledging the enlightened body, speech, and mind of the object of veneration. Step 2 -- The Descent: The practitioner kneels, then extends fully forward until the entire body touches the ground in complete prostration. Step 3 -- The Moment of Contact: While fully extended, the practitioner holds a brief recognition of complete humility before what is venerated. Step 4 -- The Rise: The practitioner draws the hands back to the chest and rises to standing.

Sacred Arts -- Thangka, Sand Mandala, Sacred Dance

Thangka (Sacred Scroll Painting): Sacred images painted on cloth or appliqued in silk, depicting Buddhist deities, mandalas, lineage teachers, and cosmological scenes according to precise iconographic specifications. A thangka is not decorative art -- it is a sacred object that has been blessed and consecrated, understood as the actual presence of the depicted being in visual form. The proportional systems, color codes, and symbolic elements of thangka painting are transmitted through specific training lineages and cannot be altered by the artist's personal preference.

Sand Mandala (Impermanence in Sacred Form): Teams of monks create an extraordinarily detailed mandala from colored sand over days or weeks, then ritually destroy it. The mandala represents the palace of a specific deity in the enlightened realm -- its creation is understood as the actual construction of that palace, blessing the surrounding area. Its ritual destruction -- sweeping the sand into a central pile and pouring it into flowing water -- is understood as the release of the blessings into the world. Nothing is held. Everything is offered. Cham (Sacred Mask Dance): Sacred masked dance performed at monastery festivals, originally linked to the subjugation of Tibet's indigenous spirits by Padmasambhava. Cham dancers wear elaborate masks representing specific deities, protectors, and animals, and perform specific choreographic sequences understood as the deity's own movement. Watching the Cham is understood as generating merit and purifying negative karma through sight alone.

Tibet Under China -- Cultural Genocide, Diaspora, and the Succession Question

The Chinese People's Liberation Army entered Tibet in October 1950. The 1959 Tibetan uprising and the Dalai Lama's flight to India marked the beginning of systematic cultural destruction. The Cultural Revolution (1966-1976) was the most devastating period for Tibetan Buddhism -- approximately 6,000 monasteries were destroyed, hundreds of thousands of monks and nuns were forced to laicize, sacred objects were melted down or confiscated, and the practice of religion was prohibited. The human cost -- in deaths, imprisonments, and cultural destruction -- is documented by the International Commission of Jurists and numerous human rights organizations as cultural genocide.

The Tibetan diaspora -- centered in Dharamsala, India, with communities in Nepal, Bhutan, Switzerland, the United States, and elsewhere -- preserved the living tradition of Tibetan Buddhism outside Tibet. The paradox of the Chinese occupation of Tibet is that it scattered Tibetan Buddhist teachers throughout the Western world, where they have had an impact on Western spiritual and psychological culture that would have been impossible had they remained on the plateau. The forced diaspora became an inadvertent global transmission of the tradition's treasures. The Central Tibetan Administration (CTA) runs 92 weekend Tibetan

language and cultural classes worldwide to preserve solidarity among the diaspora, and maintains Offices of Tibet in over a dozen countries functioning as de facto embassies.

The succession question: The 14th Dalai Lama issued a formal statement on July 2, 2025 affirming the continuation of the institution and the sole authority of the Gaden Phodrang Trust over the recognition of his reincarnation -- rejecting China's claimed authority over the process. Five UN human rights experts sent a formal communication to Beijing on July 15, 2025 expressing "grave concern." The US Congress passed a law sanctioning Chinese officials who interfere in the succession. The Panchen Lama recognized by the Dalai Lama in 1995 -- Gedhun Cheokyi Nyima, taken at age six -- has been held by the Chinese government for 30 years. The scenario of two simultaneously recognized Dalai Lamas -- one chosen through traditional Tibetan processes, one appointed by the Chinese state -- is being actively discussed by scholars and Tibetan leaders as the most likely outcome of the 14th Dalai Lama's death.

The Haligrity Lens -- Synthesis and Closing

Tibetan Vajrayana Buddhism and Bon together constitute one of the most significant and most directly relevant traditions in the entire Haligrity library -- not as a historical curiosity but as a living transmission that has been actively engaging the Western world since the 1960s and that addresses questions Haligrity asks with extraordinary precision.

The map of consciousness across dying, death, and rebirth in the Bardo Thodol is without parallel in any tradition for its specificity, its precision, and its practical orientation toward the practitioner's actual experience. No other tradition produced a comparable document. It is the most complete sacred technology for the most universal human experience -- dying -- that humanity has developed. The Five Buddha Families teaching -- that the five poisons are the five wisdoms in their unrecognized form -- is the most complete expression of the Haligrity understanding that nothing in human nature is an obstacle to be eliminated. Everything is wisdom waiting to be recognized. Dzogchen's teaching that rigpa is already and always present, that the path is recognition rather than achievement -- is the most direct Buddhist statement of the Haligrity recognition. Bon gives Haligrity the most complete indigenous Himalayan shamanic framework -- the three-world cosmology, the soul anatomy, the spirit-relationship ecology, and the soul retrieval tradition that is the direct precedent for the Living Altar concept.

On the roof of the world, between the sky and the earth, two traditions met and produced the most complete map of consciousness, death, and liberation that humanity has assembled. The Bonpo shaman's drum still beats. The Dzogchen master still rests in rigpa. The Bardo Thodol is still read at bedsides. The rainbow body still occurs in the high caves. The tradition is not past. It is present, here, now -- in the recognition that is always already available to any human being willing to look at what is looking. Grand Rising.